Continuing Education

By Jordan Douglas

ROBERT: **(Pg 34-38)** You'll have to forgive me. I'm not very good with words. I'm a numbers guy. But I never could get my thoughts in order. I think that's why when I meet people who used to know me in high school and I tell them I became a teacher, they give me one of these looks like . . . *(does the look)* . . . But, hey, I don't blame them . . . I was never the brightest kid in my class . . . I wasn't a dunce either, but I don't think anybody was expecting much of me. So when they move back home to start a family of their own and find out that I'm the one who's going to be teaching their kids . . . well, let's just say they have their reservations. But, hey . . . It's 7th grade algebra. It doesn't take a genius. Truth is, I never expected to become a teacher myself. But when I met Evangeline . . . I changed my mind. Hell, when I met Evangeline . . . everything changed.

INTRODUCTION

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ROBERT: Evangeline and I met in college. First day. Now I had barely gotten accepted and my parents were thrilled because I was the first one in my family. So, I'm sitting there in my freshman composition class ready to work my tail off and do my family proud when all of a sudden . . . BAM! In walks Evangeline . . . She looks around for a seat and I don't *think* she noticed me . . . ok, she didn't notice me . . . at all . . . but I noticed her. Her long, brown hair and her eyes . . . she had these green eyes that just . . . they were magic. Like little crystal balls or something . . . . I was hypnotized . . . they made my heart stop. Everything stopped. I don't think I even started to breathe again until class was over and she walked out of the room. Needless to say that's all I remember from my freshman comp class.

I started to wait outside class until she went in just so I could get a seat next to her. Of course, Evie was no dunce. Not at all. She was as sharp as a tack. So . . . she noticed my childish attempts at flirting . . . Our first conversation went something like this: Hi. . . hi, there . . . it's Evangeline? Right? I mean, of course it's Evangeline. I mean, I hear the teacher call your name in class and I

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see you walking around campus all the time. I mean, not like I'm stalking you or anything, 'cause that would be creepy *(uncomfortable laugh)* I mean . . . I . . . I like your . . . I mean, you have a nice . . . uh . . . book. Nice book.

EVIE: Uh . . . thank you . . . ? I see you have one too . . . The book . . .

ROBERT: Right! Right! Because we're in the same class! *(uncomfortable laugh)* Oh, God, this is going to badly . . . .

EVIE: No! No . . . you're doing great.

ROBERT: Really? You think so?

EVIE: Sure! Just go ahead and ask me to go to lunch with you after class. Go on. Give it a try.

ROBERT: Oh. Oh! Ok . . . Evangeline . . . would you go with me to lunch after class?

EVIE: Yes. I would.

ROBERT: You would? I mean you would! Great! Great! I mean . . . great! Ok. Well, I'll see you then! *(fades to present)* And that tragic conversation was actually the first thing Evie taught me . . . how to talk to girls. From that moment on she taught me everything I needed to know. I don't think I would have graduated without her help. She taught me how to study . . . how to dress like a gentleman . . . how to love. And there was nobody and nothing I loved like Evangeline . . . And even though I never felt like I deserved it, Evangeline loved me too. Almost as much as she loved kids.

Evie's dream was to be a teacher and after all she taught me, becoming a teacher just seemed like . . . like the right thing to do. I mean if I could make a difference for just one kid like Evie made a difference for me . . . then what else would I want to do with my life? I mean isn't that what it's all about? Making a difference? Ok, so I sound a little sappy, but I care, you know? I love what I do. I do. I love these kids like they were my own.

See, Evie and I never had our own kids . . . Evie had . . . Evie had ovarian cancer. Even when we got married it was already growing inside of her. Eating away at her. We had just started our life together. And here we were about to be pulled apart. But like I said, Evie was sharp as a tack and tough as nails. She fought like a champion and I was in her corner every second. I prayed all day every day. Please God. Please don't take my Evie

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away from me. When she started chemo, I held her hand as hair fell out. When she had her oophorectomy . . . when they removed her ovaries . . . I held her head as she cried. Cried and Cried. Cried for week. Even years later, sometimes I would find her crying. I didn't even need to ask. I knew why. Evie had always wanted children of her own . . . and to lose that change . . . to lose the opportunity to carry life inside of her . . . it nearly broke her to pieces. And if I had lost her to that . . . like that . . . it would have broken me beyond repair.

But with all her tacks and nails she pieced our life back together and beat it.

I thank God every day for giving me the chance to be with her. For blessing me with that time. For the next six years I didn't waste a single second. I wanted to be with her at all times. That's why we moved back to my home town and started teaching at the same school. We just couldn't be apart. Any chance I got I would run around the corner and down the hall and peak in through her classroom window. Just to see her. After years of marriage I was still a schoolboy with a crush. There are no words for it. Just . . . I love you . . . That's the only thing that comes close.

Like I said, I'm a numbers man. One number I can never forget. 4/24/1998. April 4th, 1998. I can't ever forget that day. It was just like any other day . . . I woke up in the morning . . . Evie made breakfast while I packed our lunches, and we danced in the kitchen to the Bee Gees. Then I drove Evie and I to work. Her classroom was right by the door, so I snuck into her room and gave her a kiss before the kids started to pour in. I said, "I love you." She looked up at me with those magic green eyes and said, "I love you too." There were no other words. Just I love you. And I walked down the hall and around the corner to my classroom.

Three hours later the fire alarm goes off. Now this isn't a drill. They tell us if there's going to be a drill. Now I'm thinking it's probably just some kid avoiding their history exam, so I'm not making too much of it except to follow protocol and get the kids outside as quickly and safely as possible. . So we pour out into the hall and around the corner and start making our way to the exit. All of a sudden I hear a sound like an

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explosion, it cracks the air and scares the hell out of the kids. And they all start to scream and run because now they know this isn't a drill. Something real is happening. But bang, bang, bang . . . the sound keeps coming and I know that's not an explosion. All of a sudden the doors up ahead are slammed shut and the Principal comes running back through the crowd screaming . . .

PRINCIPAL: Get back! Get back! Everyone into your classrooms NOW! There's someone outside with a gun!

ROBERT: I don't think. Instincts kick in and I know I have to protect my kids. "Alright, everyone get into the room. Go, go, go! Everyone! Come on!" And I get all of my kids into the nearest classroom, counting heads as they enter. When all the kids are out of the hallway, I lock the door and get everyone into the safest corner away from the windows and doors. We all get down on the ground. And I pray. I pray that this will go away. That this is just a nightmare and that I'm going to wake up any second and everything will be ok. Please God. Please take this away. Take this away. You took Evie's cancer, God, now please take this too . . .

No . . . no . . . Evie . . . her classroom was right by the door. And I look at the other teachers huddles with their students and I say, "Watch my kids." And I can hear them scream after me as I run out the door and down the hall into Evie's classroom. But there's nobody there. Evie?! Evie?! Where are you? Evie?! I don't even stop to think about the gunman waiting outside. I bolt through the doors. Evie?! But there's no gunman. The police have arrived. There's panic everywhere. People are screaming everywhere and . . . *(looks down)* Evie?! *(goes to her)* Evie? No . . . no . . . no No NO! Please, no, God, no . . . Evie. Wake up. Please. Please. Please. Don't take her now, God. Please give us just a little more time. Please don't take my Evie . . .

Next thing I remember I'm in the hospital. They tell me I blacked out. I ask the nurse, "Where's Evie? Where's my wife?" She doesn't answer. But she doesn't need to. I already know she's gone.

Slowly the details filter in. There were two gunmen. . . No, two boys. Two boys with guns. Just twelve and fourteen years old. I knew these boys. I taught these boys. They

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sat in my classroom. And I never . . . I mean, how could I know . . . I never would have dreamed that they were capable of something like this . . . but it was all planned out. Cold, calculated, mass murder. They pulled the fire alarm to lure everyone out of the school and then opened fire. Ten injured. Five dead. Four students . . . and one teacher. Mrs. Evangeline Foster stepped in the line of fire to save one of her students . . . Thirteen-year-old Angela Brooks.

I taught Angela too. She is the nicest, sweetest girl you'll ever meet. Has long brown hair, and bright green eyes. Just like Evie. But you don't hear about that on the news. You only hear about the misguided young boys, filled with hatred, who got their hands on a gun. Hearing their names . . . seeing their faces . . . day after day on every T.V. . . You start to hate those boys. But whenever my blood starts to boil, I just think of Evie. I think of how she loved every child for who they were. And I know that if she were in my shoes, she would find a way to forgive . . . Believe me, I try. I try to imagine how much they must have been hurting inside. But no matter how hard I try to understand . . . there are days when I wish those boys were dead and gone. It's those days that Evie is teaching me still . . . teaching me to forgive . . . to love . . . and to live. That is my continuing education . . .

It was on one of those days that I got a letter from Angela Brooks . . . If you don't mind, I'd like to read it for you . . . . "Dear Mr. Foster, I am so sorry that Mrs. Foster is gone. She was my favorite teacher. She saved my life and I would like to thank her, but I don't know how. So I would like to thank you. I know I was not a good student in algebra class, but I promise I am going to do my best from now on. I want to be a teacher someday, just like her. I think maybe that is how I will thank her. Thank you for being a good husband to Mrs. Foster. She talked about you in class all the time. So if you are sad, just remember that she loved you very much. I know you and Mrs. Foster are not my family, but I want to say that . . . I love you too."

See Evie? You made a difference . . . I miss you Evie. I love you. There are no other words.

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AWARD HISTORY

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